



TEST DRIVE
Unlimited

Rating: 7/10
Developer: Eden Games
Publisher: ATARI
Distributor: Milestone
Interface Software Ltd
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Price: Rs 999/-

ALOHA, RACERS!

Racing simulations? I'm game! But what's this... *Test Drive Unlimited* (*TDU*)? Nooo!!! Yet another arcade racer where you go around racing cars like a madman with a hundred gazillion decals supposedly for street cred? Not quite so with *TDU*. Stick around for a bit and we'll see if this highly-anticipated racer is any different.

To be honest, you'll normally find me playing simulations like *Live For Speed*, *GTR2*, *Richard Burns Rally*, *rFactor*, and such. I've played pretty much every *Need for Speed*, but haven't been very impressed with the releases post the *Porsche Unleashed / Hot Pursuit 2* era.

TDU is really quick to get going with. There aren't any formalities to complete. Select a character, get a base to run store your priceless rides a.k.a. a home. Then buy yourself a car that fits your tight budget and you're off.

The game is based in Hawaii, on an island that seems to have no boundaries. There's a good mix of landscapes—you get to drive through little residential areas, towering buildings and long highways passing

through densely-vegetated areas. You come across race events while roaming around, and you can always use the map view to jump to those locations.

The cars feel a little sluggish and refuse to turn in easily. The acceleration and braking isn't over-exaggerated. Unlike the newer *NFS* titles, *TDU* actually has a proper cockpit view, which gives it a bit of an authentic feel. You even get to ride two-wheelers—but unlike in real life, the bikes here have a complementary “reverse gear,” and it works!

The typical gameplay in most racing games can still be found—lap-style races, sprint races, against the clock, etc. No drifting and drag racing though. The AI is fairly easy to beat. There are cop chases as well. The cops don't seem to mind you driving at three times the allowed speed limit, though, but crash into other motorists and you've had it.

It appears bits and pieces of *Crazy Taxi* have made their way into *TDU* as well. Random top models are to be given rides to their destination. Drive ruthlessly or reach your destination late and you're going to get a brief sounding from them.

The game does look—it could well be one of the best-looking racers for the PC today. The only other PC racer that looks better would be *Colin McRae Rally: Dirt*. The models are well-detailed, and the textures are pretty decent considering the size of the environments. There's no excess radial blur and flashy effects you find in *NFS*, although you can pump up the blur a bit from the settings.

Performance isn't too great. At 1280 x 1024 with maxed-out details and 4x FSAA on a GeForce 7900GTX matched with a Core 2 Duo X6800, I got around 35–40 fps. The detailed models and textures may be good, but the game doesn't feel very refined—there are quite a few graphics glitches.

The car sounds are decent, and the horns honk like the ones you would find in cars from the '60s. You also get a radio with multiple stations to give you company when you're cruising down long highways.

Test Drive Unlimited is, ultimately, a fun game. It's one of those

games you can jump into for half an hour and then go back to whatever you were doing. The recent *Need For Speed* releases are focused on style, customising your rides, and fancy presentation. The new Pro Street announcement seems to suggest they'll still follow that path. In *Test Drive Unlimited*, it's just plain nonsense racing, the way it's meant to be. It can't be called a hardcore arcade racer, but it's no simulation either by any means. It's somewhere in between, inclining towards the arcade bit. Now if you'll excuse me I'm in a hurry: there's a passenger in my McLaren F1 waiting to be dropped someplace...

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